INTERPERSONAL FALSE BELIEF #51 · FORGIVING OTHERS

“If I forgive them, I'm saying what they did was okay.”

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Where it often comes from

We often resist forgiveness because we fear it erases the wrong. If someone hurt us badly, forgiving can feel like letting them off the hook, minimizing our pain, or telling the world that their behavior is acceptable. Pressure from others to “just forgive” can strengthen the resistance.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus said, “If your brother sins, rebuke him; and if he repents, forgive him.” Forgiveness and rebuke go together, so forgiving is not saying it was okay. On the cross, Jesus prayed, “Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they are doing,” though what they did was terrible. Paul writes, “Do not avenge yourselves, beloved, but leave room for God’s wrath.” Forgiving means releasing the debt and leaving justice to God. It does not deny the wrong, and it does not require us to pretend.

> *“Watch yourselves. If your brother sins, rebuke him; and if he repents, forgive him. Even if he sins against you seven times in a day, and seven times returns to say, ‘I repent,’ you must forgive him”* (Luke 17:3–4).

Also see

> “Do not avenge yourselves, beloved, but leave room for God’s wrath. For it is written: ‘Vengeance is Mine; I will repay, says the Lord.’” (Romans 12:19).

> “Then Jesus said, ‘Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they are doing.’ And they divided up His garments by casting lots” (Luke 23:34).

> “Bear with one another and forgive any complaint you may have against someone else. Forgive as the Lord forgave you” (Colossians 3:13).

> “Be kind and tenderhearted to one another, forgiving each other just as in Christ God forgave you” (Ephesians 4:32).

Common self-statements

- Forgiving them means it did not matter.
- If I forgive, they win.
- They will think they got away with it.
- I would be dishonoring my pain.
- Forgiveness means excusing what they did.
- They have to answer for it first.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I must either excuse or hold a grudge.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining that forgiveness cancels all consequences.
- Mind reading: Assuming forgiveness will be taken as approval.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling that forgiveness is dishonest.

Challenging questions

- What exactly do I think forgiveness would mean?
- Can I name the wrong clearly and still forgive?
- What would it mean to leave justice to God?
- Did Jesus forgive without calling sin okay?
- What are the consequences or boundaries that can remain?
- What does holding on cost me?

Truth summary

> Forgiving does not say that what happened was okay. I can name the wrong, grieve it, and release the debt to God. Forgiveness frees me from bitterness; it does not erase accountability or require me to pretend.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgive
- Forgiveness
- Vengeance
- Hatred
- Anger

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anger
- Communication

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Forgiveness — Matthew West
Ask God for help releasing resentment while working through real hurt.

Amazing Grace My Chains Are Gone — Chris Tomlin
Salvation and freedom come through grace rather than earning acceptance.

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Christ bears the burden of rescue rather than demanding self-salvation.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "If I forgive them, I'm saying what they did was okay"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"If I forgive them, I'm saying what they did was okay." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What exactly happened?
- ☐ What does forgiveness mean to me?
- ☐ What can remain?
- ☐ What do I release to God?
- ☐ What does holding on cost?
- ☐ What boundary do I need?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ Forgiveness is not approval.
- ☐ I can name the wrong and still forgive.
- ☐ Justice belongs to God.
- ☐ Jesus forgave while the wrong was real.
- ☐ Boundaries and consequences can remain.
- ☐ Forgiving frees me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Luke 17:3–4**
  "Watch yourselves. If your brother sins, rebuke him; and if he repents, forgive him. Even if he sins against you seven times in a day, and seven times returns to say, 'I repent,' you must forgive him."
- ☐ **Romans 12:19**
  "Do not avenge yourselves, beloved, but leave room for God's wrath. For it is written: 'Vengeance is Mine; I will repay, says the Lord.'"
- ☐ **Luke 23:34**
  "Then Jesus said, 'Father, forgive them, for they do not know what they are doing.' And they divided up His garments by casting lots."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Naming and releasing: Each week, write what happened plainly and one step of releasing it to God.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Luke 17:3–4 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I can name the wrong and still release it to God.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Forgiveness" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If there is violence, coercion, or fear of retaliation, seek private professional support before trying anything with the other person. In an emergency call 911.

- [ ] Write the wrong plainly. Describe what happened with no minimizing.
- [ ] Write what forgiveness is not. List the things you do not have to do.
- [ ] Hand it to God. Pray, "I release this debt to You."
- [ ] Set needed boundaries. Decide what limits will protect you.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "If I forgive them, I'm saying what they did was okay": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Released to God
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~If I forgive them, I'm saying what they did was okay.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, what happened was wrong. I bring it to You and release the debt. Give me freedom from bitterness without pretending, and leave justice with You. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.